

In regards to Pro-AI dismissal of LLM water consumption

Posted by u/OkSteak2954 • • 0 points • 62 comments

[A post from a pro-AI community to show their dismissal of the issue]
(<https://preview.redd.it/sbrmmaivgrjf1.png?width=887&format=png&auto=webp&s=e150450450d2fd817c7a7d22a0173577a1906049>)

[A snippet from the paper linked below that outlines general projections on water and electricity consumption](<https://preview.redd.it/thzpvsgygrjf1.png?width=990&format=png&auto=webp&s=297a61485104525358ba61afb0f414ec82648ce1>)

First of all, I should clarify my stance in all of this. I am completely anti AI due to the distasteful usage of both creative and intellectual property as data to train these LLM and the possible global impact as a result of the minimal amount of attention given by general media and AI-centered communities on these issues.

Also, I have limited my sources to only this [paper](<https://arxiv.org/pdf/2304.03271>) as to show the ease with which critical information can be found on the internet if one looks for it.

I will first address the post made in the community. If we take the lowest value mentioned in the post (10ml) and multiply it by the number of prompts inputted in ChatGPT daily - 2.5 billion (from [this blog](<https://explodingtopics.com/blog/chatgpt-users>) on site traffic) we get an estimate water usage on one platform alone to be around 25 million liters of water (25 000 cubic meters). The average yearly water consumption from a family of three in a city like Toronto is [230 cubic meters](<https://www.toronto.ca/home/311-toronto-at-your-service/find-service-information/article/?kb=kA06g000001cvc2CAA>). This means that for one day of usage on one singular AI platform the equivalent of almost 110 households' water is used. The statement "It's not hurting nature" is stemming from the inherently individualistic way these users look at the problem. If we look at a single example, the cost seems negligible, yet it is when we expand our view to the scene as a whole do we see the actual impact on our limited supply of water.

Also, when looking at water consumption by data centers, most people tend to dismiss the figures shown as they believe that most of the water is discharged back. That however is a false claim, as those numbers show the amount of water that is [consumed](<https://www.eesi.org/articles/view/data-centers-and-water-consumption>)(in the most literal sense of the word) in order to cool down their facilities.

In conclusion, it is imperative these issues be addressed in any kind of way, be it limiting AI usage to only be used in medical and scientific fields and completely cut off from public access, which I believe would be the best way to proceed. Or, if that is not possible, to find a way to decrease water consumption and/or limit public usage of the service.

Comments

u/No-Pipe8243 • 1 points • 2025-08-18 12:33 UTC

On average it takes about 7,000 liters of water to make a pound of beef. If you consider the amount of pounds of beef eaten by your average American household, about 137 pounds, that's 959,000 liters a year. This is quite a lot, but we generally except it as ok, because people need food. If you believe (like me) that AI will completely change our world, and lead to a utopia (or complete destruction, hopefully not) than the water consumption is more than worth it. I don't deny that AI consumes a lot of water, I just think in the long term, it will more than make up for it.

u/OkSteak2954 • 1 points • 2025-08-18 12:39 UTC

As I've mentioned on a previous reply here, I'm not too educated on the meat industry, however AI would not lead to a utopia the way they are using it at the current moment. This has been repeated and regurgitated a thousand times, but "I want machines to do my chores while I draw, not for machines to draw while I do my chores". At most, AI will be useful in medical and scientific fields to speed up processes related to stuff like proteins and identifying cancer cells, but these shouldn't be AI-exclusive jobs, there should also be a trained professional to oversee an make sure what the AI does is actually what it's meant to be doing.

u/Fit-Elk1425 • 1 points • 2025-08-18 18:30 UTC

<https://foldimateofficial.com/>

u/No-Pipe8243 • 1 points • 2025-08-18 12:52 UTC

I think we just fundamentally disagree on where AI is going then. I think it will radically change our world for the better, and that means I except a lot more resources being funneled into it. I can see how from your perspective the amount of water being used is unexpectable, but for me it's completely within the range of acceptability for the potential upsides. Of course we should always strive for efficiency, and reduce the amount of water used as much as possible, but if that wasn't possible in this case, I would still say full steam ahead (literally full steam ahead in this case).